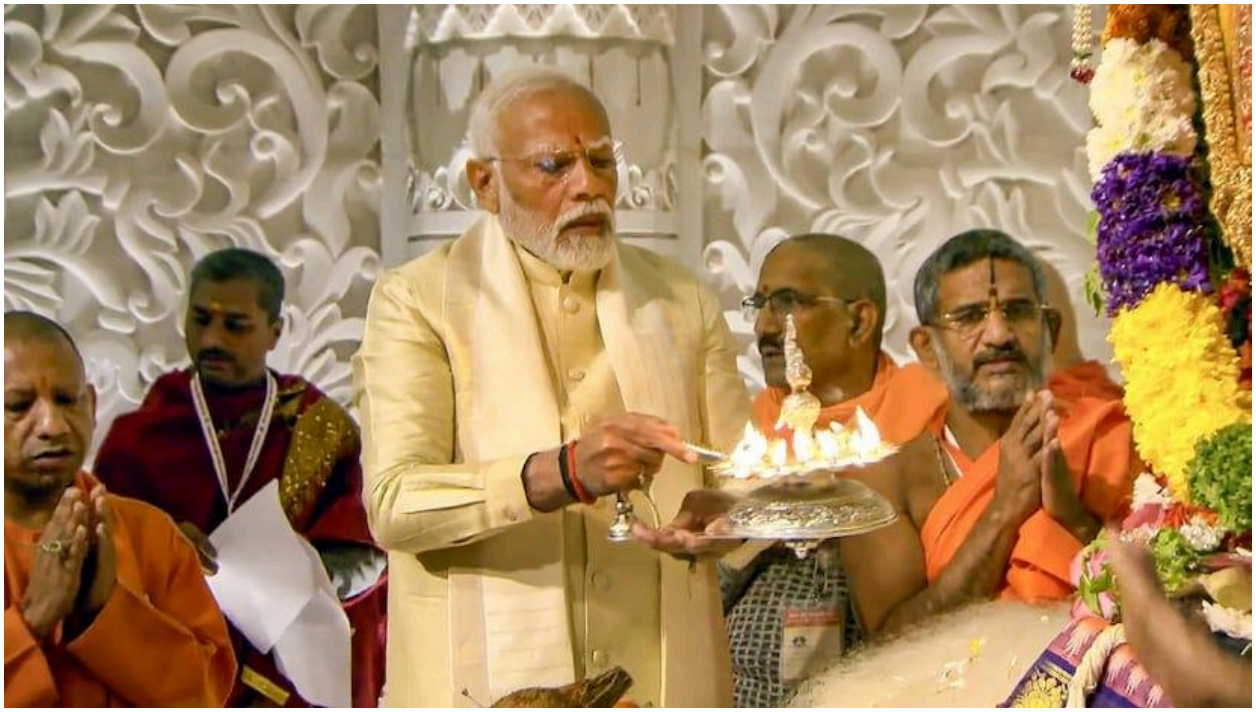
Background

Ayodhya's Ram Mandir lies on centuries-old political and religious divides Hindus revered it as Lord Rama's birthplace, and for generations, there was a mosque there। In 1992, Hindu activists demolished a mosque, which caused nationwide riots. Decades of legal struggles went on before the Supreme Court in 2019 granted the land to Hindus, allowing the temple to be built. Although a lot of people celebrated it, there are still concerns about the possibility of Hindu dominance and the danger that it poses to India's secular nature. The Ram Mandir is more than just a temple; it is a reflection of the complex interactions that exist in contemporary India regarding faith, politics, and societal issues.

2024

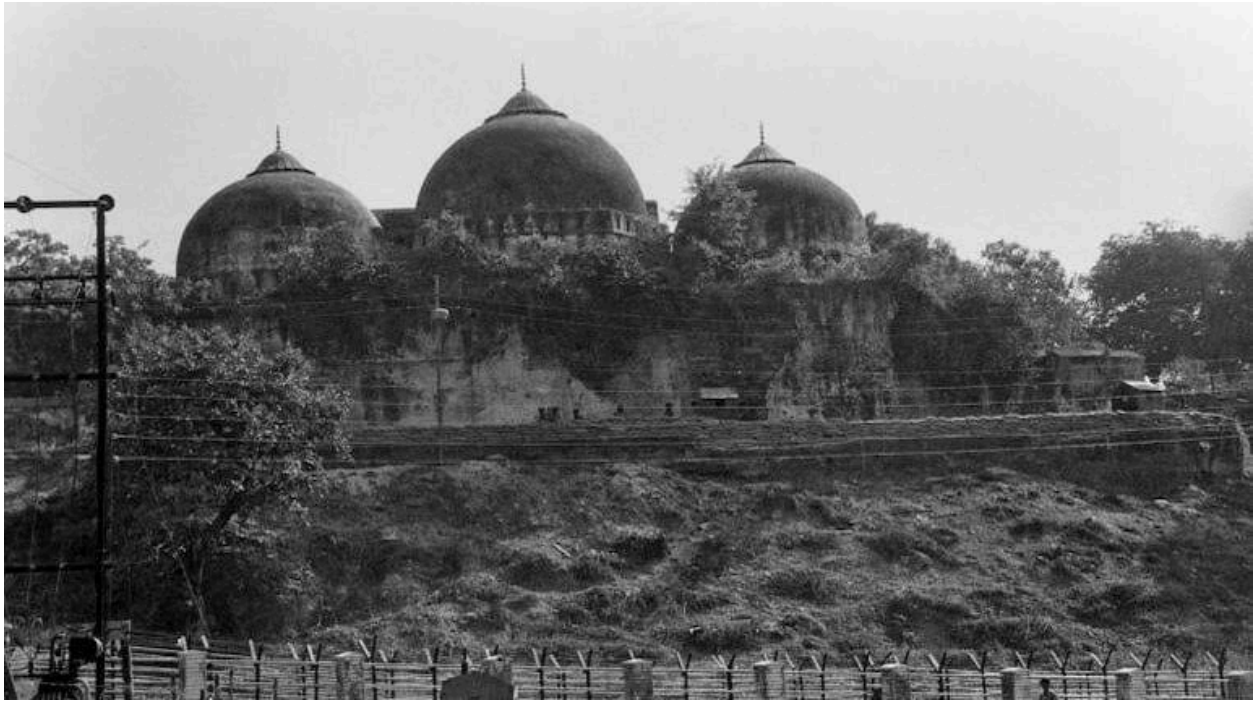
The BJP's 2024 campaign's narrative includes the opening of the Ram temple. The public sentiment centered around the religious issue is most likely to benefit Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who was the main motivator behind the construction of the temple. Ahead of the elections, the Modi government has fulfilled two of its primary religious promises: the construction of the Ram temple and the removal of Article 370. The temple will resonate in Hindi-speaking states, which have remained the main support base of the saffron party. Additionally, the new temple has the potential to establish newer connections for social integration, drawing voters from the southern states, particularly on spiritual and cultural grounds.



It was televised live while Modi, along with priests and Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), the ideology behind Hindu nationalist parties, performed religious ceremonies in a temple's sanctum. Hindus lit lamps and saffron flags with images of Ram fluttering on rooftops in many other northern cities, including some parts of Delhi. The event was screened in cinemas, and pictures were transmitted from Ayodhya to town squares and residential neighborhoods on large screens. Pran Pratishtha, which means "establishment of life force" in Sanskrit, was a ceremony that lasted about an hour. Hindus believe that chanting mantras and performing rituals around a fire will give an idol or a picture of a deity's sacred life. Behind the temple, several domestic television stations built massive sets by the side of the Saryu River, which is a tributary of the Ganges. They covered the event wall-to-wall, some saying that the consecration was the beginning of "Ram Rajya" (Lord Ram's rule) in India.

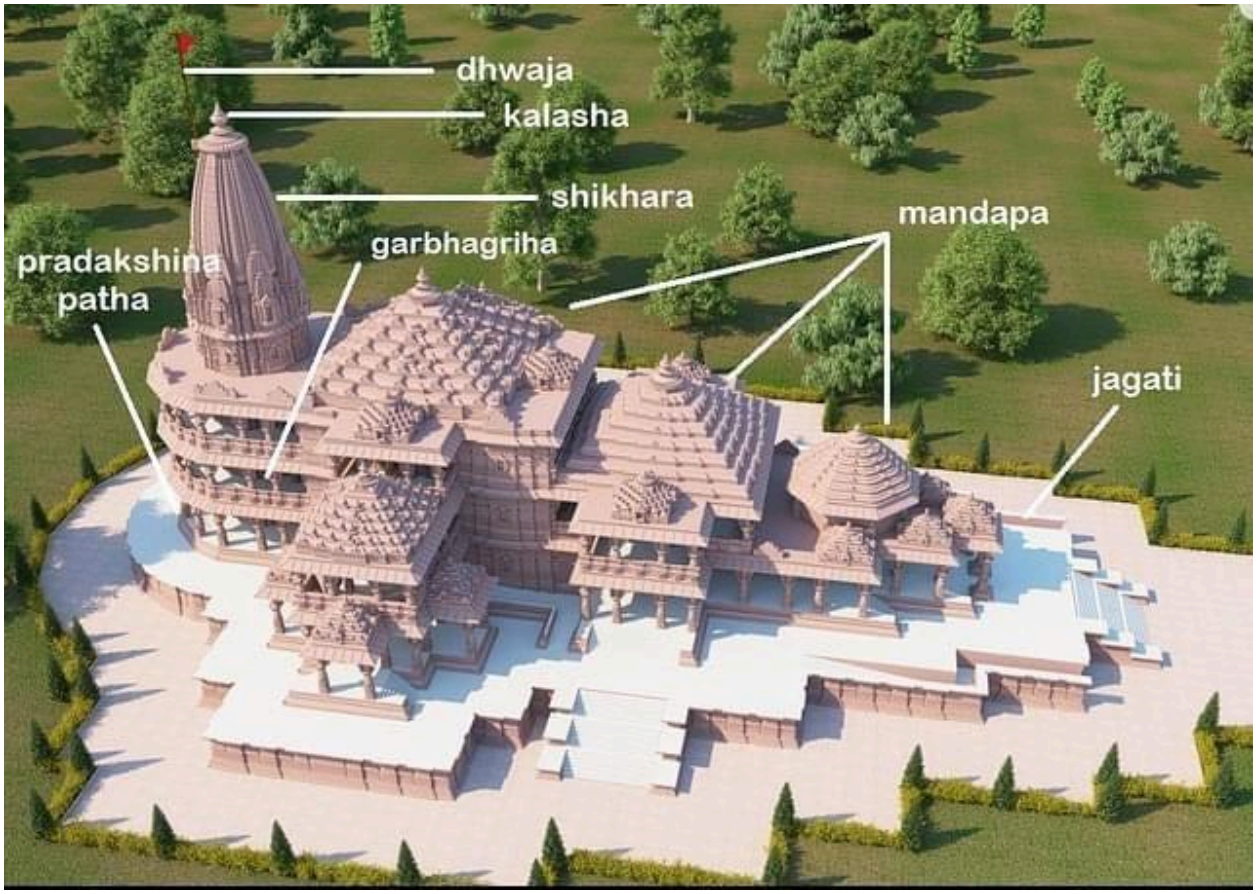
History

Beyond the symbolism of a Hindu deity, the Ram temple will convey a broader message of cultural unity and cohesion. It is social engineering by invoking god. Modi has suggested that the temple complex will have seven new temples dedicated to important Ramayan characters: Maharishi Valmiki, Shabri, Nishad Raj, Acharya Vashisht, Rishi Vishwamitra, Ahalya, and Agastyamuni. These characters are venerated by various castes and communities and in different places. Dalits venerate Valmiki, and Shabri too. Surat has a temple dedicated to her, while Kerala's Sabarimala temple is believed to be named after her. Nishad Raj is revered by the fishermen's community. Vishwamitra was a Kshatriya, and Acharya Vashisht was a Brahmin. In many parts of the country, there are temples dedicated to Ahalya and Agastya.



Structure

The temple, which is a three-story structure made of pink sandstone, extends across 2.9 hectares in a complex measuring 28 hectares or 70 acres. It will contain an idol of Lord Ram measuring 1.3 meters (4.25 feet) tall, who, according to Hindus, was born on the exact spot where the destroyed mosque was once located. The four-lane pilgrim route was formed by narrow roads; this included the 13-kilometer (8-mile) newly constructed Ram Path that leads to the temple. The city has a new airport and a large railway station that can accommodate over 50,000 passengers per day. Locals are turning their homes into homestays as major hotel chains build new properties. Awaiting a surge in demand, flower sellers and street food vendors have reopened their stores. Though the temple is far from finished, the construction costs $217 million. The place is full of rushing bulldozers and busy builders who are still working on the complex 46 doors—42 of which will be covered with a layer of gold weighing about 100 kg (220 lbs)—and a lot of wall carvings that will form the temple's final structure. The “largest agarbatti,” which is too big for the vehicle, sticks out from the back and is flanked by grown men whose mouths are painted red as a representation of Ram, Vanar Sena.



Benefits

The temple will benefit the BJP politically in three ways: First, the party will try to show that it has “resolved” the long-standing conflict between the local religious communities, fulfilling its promise in many of its manifestos. Secondly, it will add to the Prime Minister's political capital and the story that “Modi fulfills promises”. Finally, by displaying Hindu pride, the temple might encourage community votes to be more cohesive in general elections. The BJP views the construction of the Ram Mandir temple as a sign of its undivided resolve, regardless of the duration of the project. The BJP was founded in 1980 by some former members of the Janata Party, and it was initially a struggle in elections. In the 1990s, it held power for a short time and led a coalition government from 1999 to 2004. Modi in 2014 claimed to be committed to growth and raised the BJP's vote share to gain a majority of parliamentary seats with 31% of the national vote. Five years later, the party won 37% of the votes, gaining 303 seats out of 542. Modi.

The Modi government's other promises are followed by the temple project: revoking the special autonomous status of Indian-administered Kashmir and introducing a citizenship act that allowed asylum-seekers from neighboring countries to gain Indian citizenship but excluded Muslims. Modi has demonstrated that he is the man who achieves success. India's secularism, socialism, and nonalignment were fostered by the Congress party, which ruled the country for most of its first 49 years post-independence. The BJP took advantage of public dissatisfaction

and entered the void, promising “equality for all, appeasement to none” to promote an economy based on markets and to reset its foreign policy, which often favored Western interests.

Conclusion

So, the inauguration of the Ram Janmabhoomi temple as both an event and a discussion will give the BJP a symbolic fillip in its politics and help it fight caste-identity-based politics, which the Opposition alliance called "INDIA" intends to use as a major resource for mobilization in the upcoming parliamentary election. The main goal of a major day-long meeting a few months ago, attended by the party's highest leadership, was to strategize on how to put the Ram Temple to the forefront of the election narrative. The BJP concluded that outreach to persons connected to the Ram Temple would have to continue until March.By extending the outreach till March, the BJP made it clear that the temple topic will be pushed until the Lok Sabha polls. This required developing several initiatives to expand outreach.